

stepped in as a producer for Rajinikanth's films when *Enthiran* ran into financial trouble. But it took even the South-based media giant—which controls production to distribution to audio rights to its own OTT platform and successful network of TV channels—another three films to finally crack the code for a super hit Rajinikanth movie in the OTT era. Sun Pictures did not respond to *Business Today's* repeated requests for comment.

Yet, the confidence that audiences are willing to watch a Rajini film at least once, makes the trade bet on him again and again. GK Cinemas' Mathivanan says a successful opening weekend is guaranteed for a Rajini film where tickets get sold for houseful shows till Sunday by the preceding Wednesday. "It has happened even with his worst films." Says Ramanathan, "If I get his dates, I will produce a film. But there's a queue in front of me and I won't be able to break it."

CRAFTING THE STYLE

This ability to pull crowds and hold them in his sway is chalked up to his on-screen charisma—a potpourri of inimitably stylish mannerisms and punchlines, man-on-the-street looks and down-to-earth real-life persona. "I just like the way Rajini sir behaves," says S. Palani, Deputy Secretary of south Chennai's Rajini Fan Association, one of around 50,000 registered associations established for the actor between 1977 and 1999. A real estate broker by day, Palani recalls the actor speaking to him casually with an arm around him and a cigarette in his mouth around 1984-86, by which time he was already a top-billing actor. Now, his grown-up son and daughter are also Rajini fans.

A lot of it could be "divine" as several industry folks point out, but at least some of it is by design—either his own or of those around him. For instance, it was at director K. Balachander's (KB) insistence to develop his own style that Rajini came up with the signature cigarette flip within 24 hours, says Kandaswamy Bharathan, Joint Managing Director of Kavithalayaa Productions, founded by his father-in-law and Rajini's mentor KB. All good brands have a USP and Rajini's brand is built on the two pillars of style and punchlines, says Bharathan, also an adjunct faculty at Indian Institute of Management Ahmedabad and ISB, where he teaches a course on the business of films. "Much like a tagline for a corporate brand, he has a punchline, which appeals even to kids. It's usually a one-liner refreshed for every movie and created an early audience across age groups." The banner that was behind several of his hit films, including *Annamalai*, says the punchlines in the film were approved by Rajini himself.

Consider *Baashha*, the definitive Rajini film that took him to dizzying heights. It should have been the natural successor to *Annamalai*. But Rajini chose to defer it in favour of *Veera*—a comedy on infidelity. Suresh Krissna, who directed the actor in all three films, says he was totally against making *Veera*. But it was Rajini's sharp business acumen that knew there was no escaping comparison with their previous super hit film. "He told me, 'We will

THE SILVER LEAGUE



AMITABH BACHCHAN

• AGE 81 • (HINDI)
• ₹10-15 CRORE



MAMMOOTY

• AGE 72
• (MALAYALAM)
• ₹5-10 CRORE



KAMAL HASSAN

• AGE 68 • (TAMIL)
• ₹50-75 CRORE
BEFORE *INDIAN 2*



CHIRANJEEVI

• AGE 68
• (TELUGU)
• ₹45-60 CRORE



MOHANLAL

• AGE 63
• (MALAYALAM)
• ₹10-20 CRORE



SHIVRAJ KUMAR

• AGE 61
• (KANNADA)
• ₹5-8 CRORE

► Many of Rajini's contemporaries dominate across Indian languages

► But he is peerless in terms of the ₹110-crore star fee he received for *Jailer*

NOTE STAR FEE IS A FUNCTION OF VARIOUS FACTORS, INCLUDING THE MARKET SIZE OF THE LANGUAGE THEY PRIMARILY BELONG TO
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